

Turning point

The combination of international experience and homegrown development began to pay off quickly. Teams sent to events around the world left a mark, and India's campaign at the 2024 ASC — a recently designated qualifier for the Asian Games — signalled a shift.

SFI treasurer Nawaz Jabbar reflected on the achievement: "The idea of actually being able to compete in the Asian Games itself was unbelievable. And then for us to be one of the countries to compete after winning the few available slots was a little bit of a pipe dream."

According to Nawaz, who also serves as SFI's tournament director, the unprecedented outing propelled Indian surfing into the limelight. "That was a historic moment and huge achievement, and a lot of eyes were on us after that. There was a lot of publicity that we received."

That visibility translated into credibility. For the first time, Indian surfing was seen as a viable

competitive sport — and it soon cleared the long-awaited path to gaining recognition.

The SFI received approval from the Sports Authority of India (SAI) earlier this year, a major milestone that unlocked government support and resources for the sport. This endorsement has also helped attract sponsors and integrate the sport firmly within the national sports ecosystem — "It meant that surfing could finally stand on its own legs in India."

New horizons

With one major hurdle out of the way, the focus now is on building a competitive pipeline, both for the upcoming Asian Games 2026 in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, and beyond. Well aware that the big stage is only a year away, the SFI has begun its mission early to prioritise selection, international training, and nurturing young surfers.

"Age is always a thing, something we have to be wary of. The main effort is really to get more kids

involved. The team has to be larger," said Vasu, referring to nurturing younger surfers, as done in countries like Japan and Indonesia.

"The Japanese team were saying that every year, they have 600 kids taking part in their youth programmes. For India, even finding five kids is a struggle. We need to learn from them, and these events will hopefully get us more participation.

"People will see that they can make a future, and that they can be champions. India is at a very good stage in surfing, and today Asia is watching us. We will be there in the bigger leagues soon," said Vasu. Going forward, the Olympics remain a challenging but motivating goal. "I think it's going to be tough getting into the Olympics in two years. But for the edition after that, we will definitely be ready."

The ocean hasn't changed, but India's place in it has — and the next set of waves is already on the horizon.